

ARCH - ST: PORTFOLIO

Section: 006 · CRN: 19253 · Semester: Fall 2026

Days and Times: Thursdays, 6:35 PM – 7:55 PM (Aug 27, 2026 – Nov 12, 2026)

Location: [Microsoft Teams](#)

Schedule Type: Lecture

Instruction Method: 100% Online-Set Meeting Times

Instructor: Seth Looper

Credentials: M.Arch, Architecture, Rhode Island School of Design

Email: slooper@kent.edu

Phone: 603-443-7183

Office Hours: Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, and Friday, 7:00–9:00 PM via Zoom (course is fully remote)

Zoom Link (Office Hours): [Join Office Hours](#)

Preferred Contact Method: Email (response within 24–48 hours)

Course Description

Credit Hours: 1.0

Prerequisites: None

This course guides architecture students in developing an academic architecture portfolio that synthesizes design concepts and communicates architectural thinking to faculty and professional audiences. Students will learn content curation, visual storytelling, composition strategies, typography, and layout systems to create compelling, polished portfolios suitable for graduate school applications or professional employment.

Course Objectives

- Equip students to **select, organize, and present** architectural projects that effectively address the expectations of academic and professional audiences.
- Strengthen students' ability to **craft clear narratives and integrate visuals** that communicate design intent and process effectively.
- Enable students to **design and apply** grid systems and typographic principles to create consistent, professional portfolio layouts.
- Guide students to **produce and export** a final PDF portfolio that adheres to industry specifications for format, resolution, and usability.
- Cultivate a **reflective design process** by incorporating structured peer and instructor critiques to improve portfolio quality across multiple drafts.

Student Learning Outcomes (SLOs)

The following learning outcomes indicate competencies and measurable skills that students develop as a result of completing this course.

The student shall demonstrate the ability to:

1. **Curate and organize** an academic architecture portfolio by selecting and sequencing architectural projects to effectively communicate design intent and intellectual positioning for a defined audience. (PC.2)

2. **Apply** principles of visual storytelling and narrative structure by writing project statements and integrating diagrams that clearly align representational choices with architectural concepts. (PC.2, SC.5)
3. **Design and implement** cohesive portfolio layouts using grid systems and typographic hierarchy to enhance clarity, legibility, and visual coherence across multiple spreads. (PC.2)
4. **Produce and present** a professional-quality digital portfolio that meets established standards for file preparation, resolution, usability, and academic review. (PC.2)
5. **Critically evaluate and revise** portfolio work through structured peer and instructor critique, documenting iterative improvements through a revision log. (PC.6)

NAAB Criteria Alignment (where applicable)

This course supports the development of the following NAAB Program Criteria (PC) and Student Criteria (SC):

- **PC.2 Design** — How the program instills in students the role of the design process in shaping the built environment and conveys the methods by which design processes integrate multiple factors, in different settings and scales of development, from buildings to cities.
- **PC.6 Leadership and Collaboration** — How the program ensures that students understand approaches to leadership in multidisciplinary teams, diverse stakeholder constituents, and dynamic physical and social contexts, and learn how to apply effective collaboration skills to solve complex problems.
- **SC.5 Design Synthesis** — How the program ensures that students develop the ability to make design decisions within architectural projects while demonstrating synthesis of user requirements, regulatory requirements, site conditions, and accessible design, and consideration of the measurable environmental impacts of their design decisions.

Course Schedule (Fall 2026)

Week 1 — Thu, Aug 27, 2026: What Is a Portfolio? Foundations and Critical Observation

- Course + Portfolio Workshop Introduction
- Portfolio vs. Documentation Discussion
- Audience Types: Academic vs. Professional
- The Six Portfolio Components
- Eight Core Image Types
- Precedent Review: 5 Before/After Portfolio Examples
- Precedent Study Assigned: President's Medal Archive

Week 2 — Thu, Sep 3, 2026: Precedent Review: Training Your Eye on PresidentsMedals.com

- No live class this session; self-directed working session (see the course website, Session 02, for full instructions)
- Read: "Why We Look Before We Build" before starting: the rationale and the five evaluation categories
- Five categories: Storytelling & Narrative Arc, Image Selection & Curation, Visual Craft & Consistency, Sequencing & Pacing, Structure & Hierarchy
- President's Medals Archive (RIBA), 2010–2020: one project chosen per year, eleven projects total, Project Winners only
- Precedent Review Notes (template provided) submitted to the shared Class Drive by 8:00 PM

Week 3 — Thu, Sep 10, 2026: Designing Portfolio Narratives: Organizing Visual Content as a System

- Case Study: The Shawshank Redemption as Narrative Structure
- Five Principles of Narrative: Focus, Structure, Curation, Lens, Closure
- Project Statement Framework: Set the Scene / Explain the Idea / Show How It Comes Together
- Worked Example: Flexible Framework (National Building Arts Center)
- Group Exercise: Build a 7-Spread Sequence Live in InDesign

Week 4 — Thu, Sep 17, 2026: Grid Systems and Structural Logic

- Grid Theory via Architectural Column-Grid Analogy
- Baseline vs. Modular Grids
- Four Grid Types: Manuscript, Column, Modular, Hierarchical
- Group Discussion: Identify the Grid in a Published Portfolio

Week 5 — Thu, Sep 24, 2026: Building the Grid: The 12-Point System

- The 12-Point Atomic Unit System
- InDesign Setup: Document Specs, Panels, Guides
- Parent Pages Setup: Intro Splash / Project Content
- Three-Layer Hierarchy: Text / Images / Guides
- Four Paragraph Styles: Title, Subtitle, Body, Caption

Week 6 — Thu, Oct 1, 2026: Spread Composition and Grid Breaks

- 12-Column, 6–8-Row Modular Grid at 12pt Baseline (Applied)
- Five Spread Decisions: Dominance, Left-Right, Scaling, Whitespace, Composite Logic
- Pacing Across Spreads: Dense vs. Open
- Intentional Grid Breaks: Full-Bleed, Oversized Element, Deliberate Void
- 8-Item Grid-Compliance Checklist
- Group Activity: Apply Grid to Your Own Narrative Sequence

Week 7 — Thu, Oct 15, 2026: Typography as Architectural Voice

No class Thu, Oct 8, 2026 (Kent State Fall Break, Oct 8–11). Week 8 meets two calendar weeks after Week 7, not one.

- Four Typeface Categories: Modernist, Humanist & Contemporary, Editorial & Stylistic, Functional & Display
- Pairing Principles + Size Hierarchy
- Licensing and Student-Discount Resources
- In-Class: Assign a Typeface Pairing, Test on One Spread

Week 8 — Thu, Oct 22, 2026: Color, Representation & the Photographed Model

- The One-Accent-Color Rule (Or None)
- Renders vs. Drawings vs. Photography of Physical Models
- Non-Destructive Photo Editing: Lighting, Cropping, Batch Consistency
- In-Class Color Audit of Your Own Spreads

Week 9 — Thu, Oct 29, 2026: Production Standards, Digital Presence & the Self-Editing Framework

- Export Standards: Resolution, File Size, PDF Compression
- Print vs. Digital Delivery; Where Your Portfolio Lives Online
- Appropriate Use of AI Tools in Production
- Introduce 5-Category Self-Editing Audit: Narrative, Grid, Hierarchy, Typography, Technical Setup
- Group Audit of One Spread

- **NEW: Revision Log** — document how peer and instructor feedback from Weeks 1–8 has been incorporated into your spreads so far

Week 10 — Thu, Nov 5, 2026: Cover Typologies

- Seven Cover Typologies: Pure Minimal, Dark Ground, Hero Image, Bleed + Type Band, Scattered Collage, Grid/Pattern, Abstract Line
- Synthesis Matrix: Rigid ↔ Freeform, Typographic ↔ Image-Driven
- Structured Peer Review (5-Minute Presentations, Scored Checklist)
- Self-Evaluation: Technical Setup + Design Categories + Typography

Week 11 — Thu, Nov 12, 2026 — Final Session: Table of Contents Design & the Portfolio Checkpoint

- Debrief: Week 10 Peer-Review Data Shown Directly to the Class
- Six TOC Typologies: Illustrated Section Grid, Multi-Column Index, Thumbnail Gallery, Literary Chapter Index, Bold Number Cards, Narrative + List Hybrid
- Comparison Matrix: Image vs. Text, Density, Conventional vs. Expressive
- Paired Peer Cover-Review Activity

Assignments & Deliverables (Fall 2026)

Assignments are cumulative and structured to support the progressive development of a coherent, research-driven academic portfolio.

- **Precedent Review Notes (Week 2, due 8:00 PM same day)**
11 President's Medal projects (one per year, 2010–2020), submitted via the shared Class Drive.
- **Narrative Foundations (Week 3 → due Week 4)**
Project statement, narrative outline, planned images uploaded.
- **Grid Type Annotations (Week 4 → due Week 5)**
Grid type (manuscript, column, modular, or hierarchical) identified and annotated in 2 published portfolios.
- **Grid Structure File (Week 5 → due Week 6)**
InDesign file with 12-point baseline grid, margins, columns, rows, parent pages, and paragraph styles — structure only, no content.
- **Grid-Aligned Spreads (Week 6 → due Week 7)**
Submit .indd + PDF export, 7 fully grid-aligned spreads.
- **Typography System (Week 7 → due Week 8)**
Typefaces applied across all spreads; 2 candidate title-page treatments.
- **Color Treatment (Week 8 → due Week 9)**
Revise/replace any inconsistent images; finalize color treatment.
- **Self-Audit and Revision Log (Week 9 → due Week 10)**
Full 5-category self-audit of your own portfolio, plus a Revision Log documenting how peer and instructor feedback from Weeks 1–8 was incorporated.
- **Cover Directions (Week 10 → due Week 11)**
2–3 distinct cover directions built on your interior grid.
- **Final PDF Portfolio Checkpoint (Week 11)**
Fully assembled cover, chosen TOC, and two complete project spreads, submitted as PDF and .indd. This serves as the course's final examination, consistent with Kent State Policy 3-01.4.

Assessment & Grading

- **Class Participation & Engagement: 25%**
Active contribution to discussions, critiques, workshops, and peer feedback sessions.
- **Assignments & Developmental Checkpoints: 50%**
Assessment of cumulative assignments demonstrating conceptual clarity, narrative structure, representational systems, and revision process.
- **Final Portfolio Submission & Presentation: 25%**
Evaluation of final portfolio based on narrative coherence, visual organization, technical execution, and verbal articulation of work.

If you're concerned about meeting a deadline, contact Seth as early as possible — before the due date, not after — by email or during office hours to discuss an extension or alternative arrangement.

Grading Rubric (Fall 2026)

The following criteria evaluate the student's ability to organize and curate an academic architecture portfolio:

- Includes required components: cover, TOC, resume, and project sections.
- Logical sequencing and clear navigation tailored to intended audience.
- Consistent formatting and alignment across all sections.

The following criteria evaluate the student's ability to apply visual storytelling:

- Narrative sections effectively describe design intent, process, and outcomes.
- Integration of captions and diagrams enhances conceptual clarity.
- Visual content supports and reinforces the written story.

The following criteria evaluate grid and typography application:

- Grid systems applied consistently across pages.
- Professional and legible typography; clear hierarchy maintained.
- Effective balance of text, images, and white space.

The following criteria evaluate technical quality and professionalism:

- High-resolution images and proper scaling.
- PDF file meets submission requirements: correct export settings, naming conventions, and resolution.
- Final product reflects professional standards.

The following criteria evaluate responsiveness to feedback:

- Evidence of revisions between drafts and final submission.
 - Incorporation of peer and instructor feedback documented through revision log.
-

Grade Scale

Percentage	Grade	Quality Points
94–100%	A	4.000
90–<93%	A-	3.700
87–<90%	B+	3.300
84–<87%	B	3.000
80–<84%	B-	2.700
77–<80%	C+	2.300
74–<77%	C	2.000
70–<74%	C-	1.700

67–<70%	D+	1.300
64–<67%	D	1.000
Under 64%	F	0.000

Important for this course: C- or below does not fulfill graduate graduation requirements — passing grades at the graduate level are “C” or above.

Attendance & Participation

This is a semester-long, studio-style course. Attendance and active engagement in weekly sessions are expected.

Regular attendance in class is expected of all students at all levels. If you anticipate an absence, consult with the instructor individually. Legitimate reasons for an excused absence include, but are not limited to: illness and injury, disability-related concerns, death in the immediate family, religious observance, academic field trips, participation in an approved concert or athletic event, and direct participation in university disciplinary hearings.

- Students are permitted up to two absences during the semester without penalty.
- Each additional unexcused absence may result in a reduction of the Participation & Engagement portion of the final grade.
- Participation includes contributing to peer reviews, giving and receiving constructive feedback, completing in-class exercises, and sharing work-in-progress during live sessions.
- Students who anticipate an absence or scheduling conflict should notify the instructor in advance whenever possible.
- During critique and review sessions, students are expected to keep their camera on unless prior arrangements have been made with the instructor.

In all instances of absence, students are responsible for all material covered in class and for completing any resulting makeup work. An excuse from class is not a release from class responsibility.

Full university policy: [Administrative Policy Regarding Class Attendance and Class Absence](#)

Academic Integrity

This course supports an environment of academic openness and honesty. We will adhere to Kent State's Honor Pledge, which states: “In support of Kent State University's standards of excellence, honesty, integrity, and academic accountability, I pledge, on my honor, to conduct myself at all times by university rules that prohibit cheating, plagiarism, or any other form of academic dishonesty.” You must ensure that your work is original or properly cites appropriate sources.

[Administrative policy regarding student cheating and plagiarism](#)

Intellectual Property and Privacy

Any intellectual property displayed or distributed to students during this course (including but not limited to PowerPoint presentations, notes, quizzes, and examinations) by the professor remains the intellectual property of the professor. Students may not distribute, publish, or provide such intellectual property to any other person or entity for any reason, commercial or otherwise, without the express written permission of the professor. Additionally, students may refrain from distributing or publishing recordings and links to live classroom presentations, lectures, or class discussions.

Late Work

Late assignments are accepted with a 10% grade reduction per day late, up to three days, after which the assignment will not be accepted for credit unless prior arrangements were made with the

instructor. Students anticipating a late submission should contact Seth before the due date whenever possible.

Bridging Student-Faculty Expectations

Should you have any concerns with coursework, studio performance, grading, or instruction, you are encouraged to speak with your instructor in open dialogue about questions or concerns and to seek a cooperative resolution together. If dissatisfied with the resolution, then you may speak with the course or studio coordinator (if there is one). If there is none, or if concerns are still not addressed adequately, then students may discuss matters with the Program Director. In addition, CAED Advisors are always available and can offer advice about courses, point you to campus resources, or to the Student Academic Complaint Policy.

[Student Academic Complaint Policy](#)

Studio Culture

CAED Studio Culture Policy: www.kent.edu/caed/studio-culture

Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Students are allowed to use Generative Artificial Intelligence (GAI) in this course only when the instructor has indicated this use is permitted in advance. Unless given explicit permission to use these tools, each student is expected to complete each assignment without assistance from GAI.

Week 9 (Production Standards, Digital Presence & the Self-Editing Framework) is the one exception: appropriate, disclosed use of AI tools in production is explicitly taught and permitted as part of that session's content. Outside of what is covered there, the general prohibition above applies.

Required Texts / Course Materials

While no textbook is required, the following resources are recommended:

- Samara, T. (2017). *Making and breaking the grid: A graphic design layout workshop* (2nd ed., updated and expanded). Rockport Publishers. ISBN: 978-1-63159-284-3
- Hochuli, J. (2015). *Detail in typography* (English reprint). Éditions B42. ISBN: 978-2-917855-66-9
- Eisenman, S. (2008). *Building design portfolios: Innovative concepts for presenting your work*. Rockport Publishers. ISBN: 978-1-59253-438-8
- Anderson, D. (2016). *Stand out: Design a personal brand. Build a killer portfolio. Find a great design job*. Peachpit Press. ISBN: 978-0-134-13408-6

Required Software: Adobe InDesign, Photoshop, Illustrator.

Request for Religious Accommodations

The University welcomes individuals from all faiths, philosophies, religious traditions, and other belief systems and supports their respective practices. In compliance with University policy and the Ohio Revised Code, students may request class absences for up to three (3) days per term to participate in organized activities conducted under the auspices of a religious denomination, church, or other religious or spiritual organization. Students will not be penalized as a result of these excused absences.

Requests for excusal must be made in writing during the first fourteen (14) days of the semester and include the date(s) of each proposed absence or request for alternative religious accommodation. The request must clearly state that the proposed absence is to participate in religious activities and provide the particular accommodation(s) desired.

You will be notified if your request is approved or if it is approved with modifications. I will work with you to arrange a mutually agreeable alternative. You may contact the Student Ombuds (ombuds@kent.edu) for more information regarding this policy.

Student Accessibility Services (SAS)

Kent State University is committed to inclusive and accessible education experiences for all students. University Policy 3342-3-01.3 requires that students with disabilities be provided reasonable accommodations to ensure equal access to course content. Students with disabilities are encouraged to connect with Student Accessibility Services as early as possible to establish accommodations. If you anticipate or experience academic barriers based on a disability (including mental health, chronic medical conditions, or injuries), please let me know immediately.

Email: sas@kent.edu

Location: University Library, Suite 100

Phone: 330-672-3391; VP 330-968-0490

Website: www.kent.edu/sas

KC Academic Support

Kent State recognizes many students face challenges and we are committed to supporting your academic journey when you need help. Whether you are struggling in a course, need help writing a paper, or actively working to achieve your goals, use the resources below to start building your support system:

- **Where can I get help from another student who earned a good grade in this class?** Tutoring
- **Where can I go if I need assistance with how to study and meet my academic goals?** Academic Coaching
- **Who can review my writing and help me properly cite my work?** Writing Commons
- **Where should I go when I don't know where to go?** Academic Advising, TRIO Student Support Services — there may be additional resources, just ask!

Basic Needs Support and Mental Well-being

Kent State University is committed to supporting the overall well-being of our students. This support may take the form of assisting students with basic needs such as food and housing. We recognize that the absence of secure housing and access to food makes it difficult for students to achieve their best in and out of the classroom. If you, or someone you know, are unable to afford groceries or lack a safe, secure, and reliable place to live, please visit the CARES Center basic needs resource website.

Mental health challenges may also make it difficult for students to reach their full potential. KSU's mental health and wellness resource page provides information on education and awareness, mental health services, and advocacy intervention. To learn more, please visit Kent State's mental health resources and support website.